EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Passion, Money and Children: Can You Have Too Much?

Given Monday 1 December 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 10:7-9

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 10 (How a Person Should Conduct Himself in This World), Chapters 7 to 9: passion, amassing money, and children

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 1 December 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Recap: The First Three Extremes

Saadia is going through thirteen areas of life that people take to an extreme. Last week covered three:

1. **Abstinence.** The hermits said this world is full of suffering. Saadia does not entirely disagree, but there is no reason to abstain from what Hakadosh Baruch Hu has permitted, since we have to look after our health. *Perishut* is for when something forbidden is in front of us. The class also surveyed other Rishonim, including the view that the Torah does not command abstinence at all, and the Nazir.
2. **Eating and drinking.** All true that our strength comes from food and that good food and wine are pleasant, but the glutton forgets the side effects. Eat what you need to live. The Rambam: eat until you are almost full, never fully satiated, and most illnesses come from overeating.
3. **Intimacy.** Some take it to an extreme and forget its harms. Its main purpose, says Saadia, is to continue the human race.

"I'm going to go quite fast through all of this... There isn't much to discuss on this. It's quite straightforward."

Chapter 7: Passion (*Cheshek*)

Why discuss it at all?

השער הזה אם הוא גנאי לזכור, איננו יותר מגונה מדעת הכופרים

This subject is not a pleasant one to mention, Saadia admits. But throughout the book he has discussed the views of heretics, **זכרנום להשיב עליהם ולהסיר ספק מן הלב**, in order to refute them and remove doubt from the heart. He will treat this view the same way.

Their view: passion is natural, written in the stars, and from God

יש אנשים שרואים שהחשק טוב מכל מה שיתנהג בו האדם

Some people hold that following one's passion is the best thing a person can do. "Passion" here means intense longing, mainly for a person. Their claims:

- **It refines.** It purifies the spirit and the temperament until the soul becomes clear. It is "a very subtle thing."
- **It is nature.** It is drawn down into the heart; "I can't control it." It follows stages:

הבטה, a gaze;

תוחלת, a longing;

קביעות, a fixation.

Then other factors join in and draw a person after it.

- **It is in the stars.** When two people's constellations are aligned, in partial or full aspect, a single star governs both and creates love between them. The Rabbi noted that the class has seen before that the Rambam did not believe in astrology at all, while Saadia does believe in it to a degree.
- **It is from Hashem.** He created souls as whole entities, divided each into two, and placed each half in a different person. When one half finds the other, it is drawn to it. "This is a concept we find in the Zohar."
- **It is a duty.** Some even said Hashem tests people with this passion so that they learn to love and serve Him with the same intensity.

Saadia's refutation

הראיתי זה בכל מה שזכרו פתאים אין עמדה

There is nothing to it. He takes their claims one by one.

1. Hashem does not test with what He forbade. It cannot be that Hashem creates an irresistible attraction to something He has prohibited. **ואלוה לא ישים תפלה**, and **כי לא אל חפץ רשע אתה**. "Hashem's not going to put someone in a situation which they can't control."

2. The split soul contradicts Saadia's view of the soul. In the sixth essay, Saadia taught that the soul is created **together with the body** at a person's formation. This was a minority view, but he held it firmly. There is no pre-existing soul to split into two halves. The Rabbi noted that this "goes against the Zohar." Rabbis often speak at weddings of the idea that a couple's souls are two halves reuniting; that is a kabbalistic concept. Some base it on the Gemara in Yevamot that a man without a wife is incomplete, "and that is the Gemara, we accept that, of course." It means the two complement each other. But a soul literally divided before birth is something Saadia cannot accept.

3. Astrology would make love symmetrical. If the stars caused it, then whenever Reuven loved Shimon, Shimon would love Reuven equally. **ואין אנחנו מוצאים דבר כזה**. "Sometimes A has a passion for B, B doesn't have a passion for A."

4. The gaze is exactly what the Torah warns about. They say it starts with a look and grows into longing. That is precisely why the Creator told us to avoid it: **תנה בני לבך לי ועיניך דרכי תצרנה**, and **ולא תתורו אחרי לבבכם ואחרי עיניכם**.

What unfulfilled passion does to a person

Leaving philosophy aside, it is also harmful. Longing that cannot be fulfilled cripples a person's faculties. The Rabbi: "There's even an English concept for this: lovesick." It comes from Shir HaShirim, **כי חולת אהבה אני**.

Saadia lists the effects: the body wastes away, a person wanders the streets sick, with wailing, sighing, grief, a pounding heart, fainting and sleeplessness, **כי קרבו כתנור לבם בארבם**. It affects the brain and weakens thought and memory. Sometimes he collapses suddenly at the sight of the beloved, lies in shock, and might even be thought dead. **כי רבים חללים הפילה ועצומים כל הרוגיה**.

The Gemara in Sanhedrin

The Rabbi brought a case to show that the idea of being lovesick to the point of illness existed in the time of Chazal. The Gemara discusses a man who became ill with longing for a particular woman, and the doctors said he would die unless he had her. The three cardinal sins, idolatry, murder and forbidden relations, are *yehareg ve'al ya'avor*, and the Chachamim said, **ימות**, let him die. What if she merely stood before him? Even that, said the Gemara, is forbidden: "let him die."

Bound to one thing

ואיך יהיה האדם אסיר הוא ודעתו עד שלא ידע לעצמו אלוה ולא ענין ולא עולם הזה ולא עולם הבא בזולתו

How can a person make himself a prisoner, mind and all, until he knows no God, no other concern, neither this world nor the next, except the object of his passion? His devotion goes only to it. He watches doorways and lingers on every path, **שאי עיניך על שפיים**, goes out late at night and rises early, hides from people lest he be caught and die of shame, **ועין נואף שמרה נשף לאמר לא תשורני עין**. Sometimes it even leads to bloodshed: **כי נאפו ודם בידיהן**.

Even when he gets it

תשוב מתחרטת מתועבת מואסת למי שהיתה אוהבת

If he ever attains what he longed for, his soul turns to regret and revulsion towards what it loved, more than it ever loved it. **וישנאה אמנון שנאה גדולה מאד**: Amnon's terrible act with Tamar, and his hatred for her afterwards.

"This is an important principle just generally: all the things which we pursue, once you reach them, you actually become sick of it." Why? "You could say it's from guilt, but I think there's a deeper idea, that you feel you've been tricked." You believed this would solve everything and bring you happiness. You experience it, "and then, okay, fine, life moves on now." That dissonance makes a person angry, upset and guilty, and he ends up hating the thing.

He then realises **כי מכר נפשו ותורתו וכל חכמתו ושכלו**, he sold his soul, his Torah and his wisdom for something he can never take back, **עד יפלח חץ כבדו**: once the arrow has left, it cannot return.

When is passion good?

ואין הענין הזה טוב כי אם באשתו של אדם שיאהבה

Passion is good only between husband and wife, for the building of the world: **אילת אהבים ויעלת חן, דדיה ירוך בכל עת, באהבתה תשגה תמיד**. He should direct it towards his wife with understanding, as befits the pleasure of their companionship, and restrain it with strength from anything beyond that.

The empty hand

The Rabbi tied this to the parasha of that week, Vayishlach, with a story he attributed, he thought, to Rav Nachman of Breslov. A man came into a market town and shouted, "In my hand is the secret of long life," or of riches. A few people ran to ask him, and he started running away. Others saw people running and joined them, until the whole marketplace emptied and the entire town was chasing him. At last they caught him, pinned him down and forced his hand open. Inside was nothing. "That is generally the passions and the illusions of life, that we pursue them, we chase them... and then we get it and we finally open our hand and, okay, what was there? Wasn't much."

Yaakov's night-time adversary, whom some identify as the angel of Esav, is asked his name and answers, **למה זה תשאל לשמי**, why do you ask my name? One explanation is that the yetzer hara keeps changing its form. Another: "There is nothing there." A name implies a real entity, and this one is pure illusion.

The trouble is that we only remember this afterwards. That is why the Gemara in Kiddushin says that if the yetzer hara meets you, **משכהו לבית המדרש**, pull it into the Beit Midrash. The Rabbi understands this as: use your intellect. Think it through rationally. "How many times people get caught doing things and they realize it wasn't worth it. Their entire life ruined for a short pleasure."

Chapter 8: Amassing Money

Their argument

ראו אנשים כי הטוב שיתעסק בו האדם בעולם הזה הטורח בקבוץ הממון

Some say the best thing a person can do is work to gather wealth:

- Food, drink and marriage, the needs of the body, can only be had with money.
- All buying and selling, and even marriage, runs through it. "When you got married in those days... without a price, you can't get married."
- Kings only reign through it, and armies are gathered and cities conquered for it.
- People dig for hidden treasure and go to the homes of the wealthy to court them only because of it.
- Generosity, honour and charity are only possible through it: **רבים יחלו פני נדיב**.
- The Torah's blessing in Ki Tavo, **ומשלת בגוים רבים**, means ruling through wealth, as Mishlei says, **עשיר ברשים ימשול**.

"Something which we often hear, right?"

Saadia: what is good about money

He starts with what he can agree with:

שהטוב ממנו הוא מה שיבוא לאדם בלא טורח ועמל

Money that comes without excessive toil and labour is good. "A person should be trying to make money," but not at the cost of great strain. One who chases it with anxiety, sleepless nights and endless daytime toil cannot rest. **מתוקה שנת העובד אם מעט ואם הרבה יאכל, והשבע לעשיר איננו מניח לו לישון**.

The Rabbi: "I know people who are extremely wealthy who can't sleep at night." Every couple of hours they wake to check the markets, with alarm clocks set through the night. "That is not what Hakadosh Baruch Hu expects a person to have, to ruin their schedule, night, sleep, to be able to make some more money."

The dangers of making it the goal

- **It takes over your life,** like the other desires, and becomes like a fire that consumes everything. **שאול ואבדון לא תשבענה ועיני האדם לא תשבענה**.
- **Fights and hatred,** as wolves and lions fight over prey: **אריה טרף בדי גרותיו ומחנק ללבאתיו**.
- **The poor are forgotten.** He takes no notice of widows and orphans, because one who loves silver is never sated with it. **והנה דמעת העשוקים ואין להם מנחם**.
- **Loss of integrity.** "This is more subtle." Not open fighting, but losing your conscience: taking money, losing honour, betraying trust, stealing, working on the festivals and swearing falsely. **אבדה האמונה ונכרתה מפיהם**.
- **Forgetting Hashem.** Even if he gets the money, and the Rabbi has "never heard of someone tell me that I've made enough money now," he trusts in it and forgets God. **וכסף וזהב ירבה לך... ורם לבבך ושכחת את ה' אלקיך**, from Parashat Ekev. The Rabbi noted the Gemara's view that in some ways a wealthy person faces a greater test than a poor one: someone who has known poverty knows he must turn to Hashem constantly, while one with money "doesn't need to ask Hashem too much."
- **Danger to life.** Wealth can get a person killed, by robbers and bandits, or handed over to the authorities. "We know stories of people who were kidnapped, people who were killed for their money." **עשר שמור לבעליו לרעתו**.
- **Sin carried to the grave,** if it was made wrongly, and no blessing for the children: **נחלה מבהלת בראשונה ואחריתה לא תברך**.

The cycle of generations

The Rabbi described "the cycle of life." Poverty drives one generation to work very hard and make a lot of money. The next still has the father's values. Then it goes down, and within a couple of generations the money is lost and it starts all over again. "Keeping money for the next generation doesn't work."

Someone once told him he needed to make enough to buy houses for all his grandchildren. "I said, why do you need to buy houses for your grandchildren?... Why can't your grandchildren buy their own?" Giving it all to them takes away their ability to work hard as you did.

Why Hashem gave us love of money

אבל הושם האדם לאהוב הממון לשמור מה שחננו הבורא ולא יאבדנו

We were given a love of possessions so that we look after what the Creator has graciously given us and do not waste it. **ברכת ה' היא תעשיר ולא יוסיף עצב עמה**. "It's an interesting idea, this." Without it, we would have things and not take care of them.

This too fits the week's parasha. **ויותר יעקב לבדו**: Yaakov's family crossed the river and he was left alone. Chazal, quoted by Rashi, say he had gone back for some **פכים קטנים**, small jars. Crossing a river at night was no simple feat, but he did it, because this is what Hakadosh Baruch Hu had blessed him with, "I need to look after it, I mustn't waste it."

Chapter 9: Children

"Some of these things are old fashioned, but some of them really quite speak to us in this generation. And I think the next one also speaks to us."

Their argument

ראו אנשים שישתדלו בבקשת הבנים

Some people say the sole focus of life should be having more and more children:

- They bring joy to the soul and delight to the eye.
- Without them the world would not continue.
- They are a person's support in old age: the more children, the more people to look after you.
- Good children remember you kindly after your death.
- They are the natural objects of compassion and mercy.
- The great prophets all asked for them: Avraham, **הן לי לא נתת זרע** (Lech Lecha); Yitzchak, **ויעתר יצחק לה' לנכח אשתו כי עקרה היא** (a couple of weeks ago); Rachel, **הבה לי בנים ואם אין מתה אנכי** (the previous Shabbat's parasha).
- A father who teaches his child Torah and mitzvot earns reward: **אב לבנים יודיע אל אמתך**.

Saadia: right in principle, wrong to make it everything

וראיתי נכון בבנים שיחננם הבורא לעבודתו כרצונו

It is right to have children whom the Creator grants, to bring them up to serve Him. Their mistake is focusing on this to the exclusion of everything else.

ומה תועלת יש בהם אם לא יהיה להם מזון וכסות ומחסה, ומה טוב יש בגידולם אם לא יהיה להם חכמה ומדע

What benefit are children with no food, clothing or shelter? What good is raising them without wisdom and knowledge? What is compassion worth if you cannot provide the most basic needs?

The Rabbi on halacha and balance

"I think this is an important point." In some circles people say that birth control is forbidden in every case and a person should never use these things. "There's no source for that." He set out the halacha:

Mitzvah	Source	What it requires
פרו ורבו	Torah	A boy and a girl, following Beit Hillel. The obligation is on the man (some say the woman too, but most likely only the man)
שבת	Chachamim	Continuing to have children, from **לא תהו בראה לשבת יצרה** and **בבקר זרע את זרעך ולערב אל תנח ידך**. Only on the man

So of course Saadia, and everyone, agrees that the Torah and Chazal want a person to have as many children as possible. But it has to be balanced against other things: can you provide for them physically, mentally and educationally? "It's not quantity over quality. This is the key point Saadia is making, and that's the point we forget." It is not only about having fifteen children; it is also about each one being properly looked after. Otherwise it only brings pain to the parents, and how can parents expect anything from children to whom they could not give the basics?

The burdens of children

Saadia lists them bluntly:

- The pain of pregnancy and birth, **בעצב תלדי בנים**, and sometimes the mother dies in childbirth, **ויהי בצאת נפשה כי מתה**, Rachel at Binyamin's birth, in that week's parasha.
- The father's labour and danger to feed them, **ואפרחיו יעלעו דם**. "Sometimes a person has too many kids, they suck the blood out of a parent."
- The trouble of raising them, nursing their illnesses and preparing their medicines. "How many times do we wake up at night from the child crying."
- If a child dies, the grief is terrible.
- If they live, the fear for sons, that they will grow up properly, keeps a parent awake: **משדד אב יבריח אם, בן מביש ומחפיר**. And the fear for daughters, as Chazal say, keeps a father up at night.
- If they turn out well, there is hope; if they rebel, **דור עקש ופתלתל**.

Why Hashem gave us love for children

אבל שם האב לאהוב את הבנים... שלא יקוץ בהם

Saadia's conclusion: the Creator placed love for children in parents so that they would not grow weary and disgusted with them. **הנה נחלת ה' בנים שכר פרי הבטן**.

The Rabbi was candid: "This I can't agree, I'm not sure. Okay, this is what he says." Then he developed it. Think about how much we give our children and what we get back, "I'm not talking about the *nachat* and the pride, that's a different thing." In any other relationship, giving so much and receiving so little would be called toxic. "You would get divorced, or... you would leave the friendship." So Hashem gave us love for our children to cover over the fact that they take from us. He added that there is also a biological aspect: this is our seed and our continuation.

Summary

1. **Passion:** claims that it is natural, astrological or a divine split of souls fail. Hashem does not test with the forbidden; the soul is created with the body; love is not always mutual; and the Torah warns about the very gaze that starts it. Unfulfilled, it makes a person sick; fulfilled, it often turns to revulsion, as with Amnon. Its place is in marriage.
2. **The empty hand:** the things we chase are often illusions. Pull the yetzer hara into the Beit Midrash: think it through with your intellect.
3. **Money:** good when it comes without consuming your life. Made into the goal, it brings sleeplessness, fights, neglect of the poor, loss of integrity, forgetting Hashem, danger and unblessed inheritance. The love of money exists so that we look after what Hashem gave us, like Yaakov's small jars.
4. **Children:** a great good and a mitzvah, but quality and not only quantity. A parent must be able to feed, house and educate them. Hashem gave us love for them so that we keep giving.

Coming Up

- **Next week:** Chapter 10 and onwards: those who live only to build up the world, those who live only for long life, and those who pursue status. The Rabbi hopes to finish the book around the end of the year.

- **Tomorrow night (Tuesday):** the Rambam's Principles of Faith continue, with the second and third principles, the unity of Hashem and His incorporeality.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/Wf7ZJsccmfI · More shiurim: rabbikada.com